

Absolutely — **staff** is a very strong polysemy target because your passage uses it here:

> “The **staff** know many customers by name...”

Here **staff** means **the employees who work for a business or organization**. But **staff** also has major meanings involving **a long stick/pole**, **a symbol of office or authority**, **musical notation**, and the verb **staff = provide workers for an organization or event**.

Word family: **staff / staffed / staffing**

Base word: staff

Plural/collective use: staff / staffs

Verb forms: staff, staffs, staffed, staffing

Related noun: staffing

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Important grammar point:

> **staff** is often a **collective noun**.

In BrE, especially:

> “The staff **are** friendly.”

In AmE, especially:

> “The staff **is** friendly.”

Both patterns exist, depending on dialect and whether the group is viewed collectively or as individuals.

Meaning in your passage: **staff = employees of a business/organization** — 員工 ; 職員

Your sentence:

> “The **staff** know many customers by name...”

Here **staff** means:

> **the group of people employed by a business or organization.**

繁體中文 :

受僱於某間公司、商店、學校、機構等的一群工作人員 ; 員工、職員

Natural translation:

> “The staff know many customers by name.”

「店員 / **員工**認得很多顧客的名字。」

So here:

> **staff = 店內員工 / 工作人員**

1. **staff = employees collectively — 員工；職員；工作人員**

This is your exact source sense.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The **staff** know many customers by name.”

「**店員 / 員工**認得很多顧客的名字。」

Practice 2

> “The hotel **staff** were very helpful.”

「酒店**員工**非常樂於幫忙。」

Practice 3

> “All staff must attend the meeting.”

「所有**員工**都必須出席會議。」

staff = 一間企業 / 機構受僱工作的整體人員

2. **staff = particular group of employees within an organization — 某部門職員；工作團隊**

A common institutional sense.

Practice 4

> “The teaching **staff** met after school.”

「**教學人員 / 教師團隊**放學後開會。」

Practice 5

> “The medical staff responded quickly.”

「**醫護人員**迅速作出反應。」

staff = 某個部門 / 職能中的工作人員整體

Common:

- * teaching staff
- * medical staff
- * support staff
- * administrative staff

3. **staff = number/workforce of employees — 人手；人員編制**

A common business/workplace sense.

Practice 6

> “The shop is short of **staff**.”

「這間店**人手不足**。」

Practice 7

> “The company increased its staff last year.”

「公司去年增加了**人手 / 員工編制**。」

staff = 從人數、配置角度看的員工隊伍

This often translates more naturally as:

- * 人手
- * 人員
- * 編制

rather than simply 員工.

4. ****staff = verb, provide workers for something — 配置員工；派員****

A major verb meaning.

Practice 8

> “The bakery is ****staffed**** by six people.”

「這間麵包店由六名員工****負責當值 / 配置人手****。」

Practice 9

> “The reception desk is ****staffed**** all day.”

「接待處全天都有****職員當值****。」

****staff — verb = 安排 / 配置人員去負責某個地方、部門或活動****

5. ****staff = employ people in a role/organization — 為.....配備人員****

Practice 10

> “The company ****staffed**** the new branch quickly.”

「公司很快便為新分店****配備好人手****。」

Practice 11

> “The event was ****staffed**** by volunteers.”

「這項活動由義工****負責人手安排 / 當值****。」

****staff = 為某個單位安排足夠工作人員****

6. ****staffing = provision/organization of employees — 人手配置；人員安排****

A major related noun.

Practice 12

> “The bakery has a ****staffing**** problem at weekends.”

「這間麵包店週末有**人手配置問題**。」

Practice 13

> “Staffing levels are higher during busy periods.”

「繁忙時段的**人手水平 / 人員配置**較高。」

****staffing = 安排、配置和維持工作人員的情況 / 過程****

7. ****staff = long stick/pole used for support — 杖；長杖****

A completely distinct literal noun meaning.

Practice 14

> “The traveller carried a wooden ****staff****.”

「那名旅人拿著一根木製****長杖****。」

Practice 15

> “He leaned on his staff while walking.”

「他走路時靠著****手杖 / 長杖****。」

****staff = 長而直的棍 / 杖，可用來支撐身體或行走****

This sense is more literary/historical than everyday ****walking stick****.

8. ****staff = ceremonial symbol of authority — 權杖；儀仗杖****

A historical/ceremonial extension.

Practice 16

> “The official carried a ceremonial ****staff****.”

「那名官員拿著一根象徵身份的****儀仗杖 / 權杖****。」

Practice 17

> “The staff symbolized his office.”

「那根**權杖**象徵他的職位。」

staff = 象徵權力、職位或宗教身份的長杖

Register:

- * historical
- * ceremonial
- * religious

9. **staff = musical staff / stave — 五線譜**

A major music meaning.

Practice 18

> “Write the notes on the **staff**.”

「把音符寫在**五線譜**上。」

Practice 19

> “The melody is written on the upper staff.”

「旋律寫在上方的**五線譜**上。」

staff — music = 用來書寫音符的五條平行線

Regional terminology:

- * **staff** = common in AmE
- * **stave** = common in BrE, though both are understood

10. **staff = one set of five musical lines — 一組五線譜線**

Practice 20

> “Each **staff** contains five lines.”

「每一組****五線譜****有五條線。」

Practice 21

> “The score uses two staves.”

「這份樂譜使用兩組****五線譜****。」

****staff = 樂譜中一組五條平行線****

Plural:

> staves

> or

> staves

depending on variety/style.

11. ****support staff = 支援人員****

A common workplace compound.

Practice 22

> “The school hired more ****support staff****.”

「學校聘請了更多****支援人員****。」

Practice 23

> “Support staff handle administrative tasks.”

「****支援人員****負責行政工作。」

****support staff = 為主要專業 / 前線人員提供行政、技術或後勤支援的人員****

12. ****administrative staff = 行政人員****

Practice 24

> “The ****administrative staff**** manage bookings.”

「**行政人員**負責管理預約。」

Practice 25

> “Administrative staff work in the main office.”

「**行政職員**在主辦公室工作。」

administrative staff = 負責行政、文書和辦公管理的人員

13. **staff member = 一名員工；職員**

A useful countable expression.

Practice 26

> “A **staff member** helped me.”

「一名**員工**幫了我。」

Practice 27

> “Each staff member received training.”

「每名**員工**都接受了培訓。」

staff member = staff 這個集體中的一名個別員工

Very useful because bare **staff** is collective.

Important distinction: **staff vs employee**

staff

usually collective:

= 員工整體

employee

one individual employed person:

= 僱員

> “The staff are friendly.”

= 員工整體很友善。

> “She is an employee.”

= 她是一名員工。

So:

> one staff ❌ usually

> one staff member ✅

> one employee ✅

Important distinction: **staff vs worker**

worker

broad:

someone who works, often emphasizes labour/work activity.

staff

people employed by a particular organization.

> factory workers

> = 工廠工人

> hospital staff

> = 醫院職員

Overlap exists, but nuance differs.

Important distinction: **staff vs crew**

crew

usually a team working together in a specific operational setting:

* aircraft

* ship

* film production

* technical team

staff

broader employees of an organization.

> hotel staff

> = 酒店員工

> cabin crew

> = 機艙服務員 / 機組人員

Not interchangeable everywhere.

Important distinction: **staff vs team**

team

= people working together toward a specific goal.

staff

= all employees of an organization/unit.

All team members may be staff, but not all staff necessarily form one team.

Important distinction: **staff vs personnel**

staff

ordinary workplace term.

personnel

more formal/administrative:

= 人員

> staff training

> = 員工培訓

> personnel records

> = 人事紀錄

Personnel often appears in HR/military/administrative contexts.

Important distinction: **staff vs workforce**

staff

employees of one organization/unit.

workforce

all workers available/employed in a company, sector, or country.

> bakery staff

> = 麵包店員工

> national workforce

> = 全國勞動人口

Important distinction: **staff vs management**

staff

may include all employees broadly, but often contrasts with management.

management

= people responsible for directing/controlling the organization.

> staff and management

> = 員工與管理層

Context determines whether managers are included under **staff**.

Important distinction: **staff — collective vs staff members**

Collective:

> “The staff are friendly.”

= 員工整體很友善。

Individual:

> “Three staff members were working.”

= 有三名員工正在工作。

This is a key grammar point.

Important distinction: **staff — employees vs staff — pole**

Employees:

> “The staff know the customers.”

= 員工認得顧客。

Pole:

> “He carried a staff.”

= 他拿著一根長杖。

Completely different meanings.

Excellent MCQ contrast.

Important distinction: **staff — workplace vs music**

Workplace:

> staff = 員工

Music:

> staff = 五線譜

Same spelling, unrelated modern senses.

Very strong MCQ material.

Important distinction: **staff vs stave in music**

staff

especially AmE

stave

especially BrE

Both:

= 一組五線譜線

So for learners:

> musical staff = 五線譜

> musical stave = 五線譜

Important grammar note: **staff can be singular or plural in agreement**

BrE collective emphasis:

> “The staff **are** friendly.”

Very natural.

AmE collective-unit emphasis:

> “The staff **is** friendly.”

Also standard.

When emphasizing individuals:

> “The staff **are** wearing different uniforms.”

is especially natural in BrE.

For your passage:

> “The staff **know** many customers by name.”

This follows the plural collective pattern.

Important grammar note: **staff** is not normally countable for individuals

Avoid:

> **a staff** = one employee ❌

Use:

> a staff member

> an employee

> a member of staff

BrE especially:

> **a member of staff**

Important distinction: **staffed** vs **employed**

employed

focuses on having a job with an employer.

staffed

focuses on whether a place/role has workers assigned.

> “She is employed by the bakery.”

= 她受僱於麵包店。

> “The counter is staffed by two people.”

= 櫃檯有兩名員工當值。

Important distinction: **staffing** vs **recruitment**

staffing

= overall provision/allocation of personnel.

recruitment

= process of finding/hiring new employees.

A business may have a staffing problem because of:

- * scheduling
- * absences
- * turnover
- * insufficient recruitment

So they are related but not identical.

Important note on polysemy depth

****Staff**** has a genuinely strong but manageable inventory:

1. ****employees collectively****
2. ****staffing / provide workers****
3. ****long pole / ceremonial staff****
4. ****musical staff****

The workplace sense has several contextual translations:

- * 員工
- * 職員
- * 人手
- * 人員編制

but these should not be over-split into separate lexical meanings unless the concept changes.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern inventory includes:

- * ****staff — employees**** = 員工 / 職員
- * ****staff — department group**** = 某類工作人員
- * ****staff — workforce level**** = 人手 / 人員編制
- * ****staff — verb**** = 配置 / 安排員工
- * ****staffed**** = 有人員當值 / 配置人手的

* **staffing** = 人手配置
 * **staff — long pole** = 長杖
 * **staff — ceremonial** = 權杖 / 儀仗杖
 * **staff — music** = 五線譜
 * **staff member** = 一名員工
 * **support staff** = 支援人員
 * **administrative staff** = 行政人員

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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staff — employees	受僱於某公司、商店、學校或機構的一群工作人員
staff — department group	某一特定職能 / 部門中的工作人員整體
staff — workforce	從人數 / 配置角度看的工作人手或人員編制
staff — verb	為某地方、部門或活動安排 / 配置工作人員
staffed	已配置工作人員 / 有人當值的
staffing	人員的安排、配置與數量管理
staff — pole	用作支撐、行走或象徵身份的長杖
staff — ceremonial	象徵權力、職位或宗教身份的儀仗杖 / 權杖
staff — music	樂譜中用來書寫音符的一組五條平行線
staff member	員工群體中的一名個別職員

For your original sentence

> “The **staff** know many customers by name...”

The exact meaning is:

**staff = Golden Crust 麵包店裡受僱工作的店員 / 員工整體，而不是單一某一位員工。 **

Natural translation:

> **「店員認得不少熟客的名字。」**

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > **the staff** → 員工整體
- > **a staff member** → 一名員工
- > **short of staff** → 人手不足
- > **staff the counter** → 為櫃檯配置人員
- > **staffing levels** → 人手配置水平
- > **a wooden staff** → 木杖

> ****musical staff**** → 五線譜

> ****staff vs employee**** → 員工整體 vs 一名僱員